

"The Ice Cave"

Lupin Creative Writing — Survival/Danger Story 13 August 2026

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A genuinely tense idea, told too fast — and with more slips than a first read shows.

You've got a real hook here — a friend dangling over an ice hole, a countdown rescue, a wall of ice sealing the exit. But the piece rushes through the middle in a handful of lines, and it carries 8 genuine errors in under 200 words: two misspellings of words you'd already spelled correctly elsewhere on the page, the same "off" instead of "of/on" mistake twice, a missing word, and a run-on sentence.

Continuity from your last report: your last piece was flagged for trailing off on "..." instead of a real ending — this is now **three pieces in a row** that stop this way. It's clearly become a habit under time pressure, not a one-off. This time, make finishing the story the very last thing you do before you put your pen down, even if it's just one sentence.

MARK BREAKDOWN

Content & Ideas

4/7

A strong, genuinely dangerous scenario (an ice-hole rescue against a collapsing cave), but it's compressed into a handful of lines — the actual rescue happens in one sentence with no sense of how close, cold or frightening it really was.

Structure & Organisation

4/6

Good instinct for pacing — two separate one-line paragraphs (the opening, and "He was hanging on by a strand of hair") used deliberately for dramatic pause. Let down by the unfinished ending.

Style: Vocabulary & Variety

3/6

Some precise words ("musty", "mysterious", "tiresome") and a reach for a simile/pun ("like a chicken with its head off"), but a missing word blunts the joke and "hole" and "path" both repeat.

Technical Accuracy

2/6

8 genuine errors in under 200 words — two misspellings of words spelled correctly elsewhere on the same page, the "off" for "of/on" mistake made twice, a missing word, and one run-on sentence. Visible self-editing is a real strength, but this needs a proper reread before you call a piece finished.

THE ICE CAVE

It was a choice between life and death.

Nobody had ever thought that this would ever happen. Earlier, my friends and I were planning to explore this dark, musty cave, which was in an icy mountain. We checked that we had everything: ice picks, helnets¹, flashlights and food.

We started off by climbing using the metal ice piks² until we reached the mouth off³ the mysterious cave. Inside⁴, there were two paths, so we split into two groups of two.

Moments later, one of our friends, Bob, was suddenly yelling his⁵ like a chicken with its head off. "Help!" he screamed while we came darting from the other path.

He was hanging on by a strand of hair.

In front of us there was a large, deep hole, where he was gripping an ice pick. Based off⁶ the ice, we could tell it was going to break in any minute⁷. Fortunately we could reach his hips, where we started to pull, strapped a rope⁸.

"3... 2... 1... Pull!" I chanted, and after thirty tiresome minutes which felt like a day, we managed to pull him out. Suddenly a wall of ice covered the exit just as we were leaving. We were trapped...

CORRECTIONS

1 Spelling.
"helmets"

2 Spelling — same word as above ("picks"), correct earlier in the piece, misspelled here.
"picks"

3 Wrong preposition — "the mouth off the cave" should be "of."
"...the mouth of the mysterious cave."

4 Missing full stop — "cave inside" runs two ideas together as one sentence.
"...mysterious cave. Inside, there were two paths..."

5 Missing word — the joke needs "head off" before "like a chicken", or it just reads as "yelling his... like a chicken."
"...was suddenly yelling his head off, like a chicken with its head off."

6 Wrong preposition again — "based on," not "based off." This is the same mistake as Correction 3, worth remembering as one rule, not two separate slips.
"Based on the ice, we could tell..."

7 Wrong preposition — "in any minute" isn't standard English.

"...it was going to break at any moment."

8 Two actions run together with no joining word, so it's unclear what happened first — did they strap the rope, then pull?

"...we strapped a rope around him and started to pull."

STRENGTHS

STRUCTURE & CRAFT

- Opening straight into danger with *"It was a choice between life and death"* as its own line — a real hook, no slow build-up needed.
- *"He was hanging on by a strand of hair"* isolated as its own one-line paragraph — you're using this device on purpose now, not by accident.
- The *"3... 2... 1... Pull!"* countdown is a good instinct for building tension through dialogue rather than description.

EDITING & LANGUAGE

- Real evidence of redrafting as you write — you crossed out and rebuilt the "large deep hole" and the group-splitting sentence rather than leaving your first attempt.
- Reaching for imagery under pressure with the *"chicken with its head off"* simile, even though the wording needs tightening.
- Good precise word choices: *"musty"*, *"mysterious"*, *"tiresome"*.

NEXT STEPS

Focus for next time — 1) Finish the story properly — three pieces in a row have stopped on "...", so plan your last line before you start writing, not after. 2) Slow the rescue down: add a sentence or two of what it looked, sounded or felt like as the ice cracked, instead of jumping straight to "we managed to pull him out."

3) Read your last sentence back before moving on — that's how you'll catch missing words like in Correction 2.

MARKED AGAINST A FOUR-STRAND CREATIVE-WRITING RUBRIC (CONTENT & IDEAS / STRUCTURE / STYLE / TECHNICAL ACCURACY) SCALED TO 25 · SUMMIT TUITION